

DIPLOMATIC WORKING DOCUMENT — MODULAR ANNEX

ANNEX Pa

**Patrol Boat and
Fast Attack Craft
Protocol**

Zone-Based Rule Architecture for Small Military Vessels in the Strait of Hormuz

Modular · Self-Contained · Incorporable by Reference

MOU Pertaining to PEACE (v7.0) · June 2026

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Preamble

The Parties recognize that small, fast military vessels — including but not limited to IRGC-Navy fast attack craft, PGSA patrol boats, and any vessel capable of sustained speeds exceeding 25 knots — present unique risks of unlawful interdiction, harassment of commercial shipping, and miscalculation leading to escalation. This Annex establishes a bright-line rule set for all Iranian patrol craft, regardless of their nominal authority or flag. The United States and coalition forces observe reciprocal restrictions on their small vessels within the transit corridor.

The framework architecture acknowledges that the speed, maneuverability, and offensive capability of fast attack craft make them qualitatively different from conventional naval vessels. A frigate's presence is visible, predictable, and de-escalatable. A fast attack craft's presence is sudden, proximity-dependent, and escalation-prone. This Annex addresses that asymmetry through zone-based prohibitions, mandatory telemetry, and graduated consequences.

The following principles govern the interpretation of this Annex:

- Bright-line clarity: Every rule in this Annex operates as a clear, verifiable standard. Ambiguity creates miscalculation; precision creates compliance.
- Zone-based differentiation: The architecture applies different rules to different maritime zones — the CTC, territorial waters, and international waters — reflecting the distinct legal and operational characteristics of each zone.
- Symmetry of obligation: The restrictions on Iranian small vessels carry corresponding restrictions on U.S. and coalition small vessels. Neither Party enjoys a unilateral freedom of action that the other lacks.
- Telemetry as trust: Automatic Identification System (AIS) broadcasting and telemetry data serve as the primary verification mechanism. Vessels that broadcast their position, status, and intent are vessels that the architecture treats as operating in good faith.
- Graduated consequences: Violations trigger proportionate consequences through the Tier system. Minor infractions receive minor responses; major provocations receive major responses. The architecture excludes zero-tolerance overreach and zero-consequence impunity equally.

Annex Pa fills the most dangerous gap in the Hormuz maritime architecture: the behavior of small, fast, heavily armed vessels that can close to lethal range in minutes. Every major Hormuz escalation of the past two decades involved small vessels exploiting ambiguity

about their intent. This Annex removes that ambiguity. It says: broadcast or be presumed hostile. Stay out of the corridor or face consequences. Approach a commercial vessel and the architecture responds automatically.

Article 1 — Definitions

For the purposes of this Annex, the following terms have the meanings set out below. Terms not defined here have the meanings given in MOU Article 1.6 or Annex Mi.

Term	Meaning
Patrol boat	Any vessel under 500 gross tons, operated by Iranian military, paramilitary, or law enforcement forces (including IRGC-Navy, PGSA, and conventional Navy), used for coastal patrol, interdiction, or security missions. Includes RHIBs when operated by military or paramilitary forces.
Fast attack craft (FAC)	Any patrol boat capable of sustained speed exceeding 25 knots, armed with machine guns, cannons, rockets, or missiles, and designed or employed for offensive naval operations. The FAC designation applies regardless of nominal classification. Sustained speed is measured by MSB radar tracking over a 15-minute moving window. A vessel receives the FAC designation if its speed exceeds 25 knots for a cumulative total of 5 minutes or more within any 15-minute rolling window, or if its speed exceeds 25 knots for any single continuous period of 4 minutes. This measurement method prevents tactical gaming through speed bursts.
Commercial Transit Corridor (CTC)	The 10-nautical-mile-wide lane defined in Annex Mi for commercial shipping. The CTC's precise coordinates are published by the MSB and updated quarterly.
PGSA territorial waters zone	Iranian territorial waters extending 12 nautical miles from Iran's internationally recognized baseline, within which the PGSA exercises law enforcement authority under MOU Article 3.3.
Harassment	Any intentional act that interferes with a commercial vessel's safe passage, including: approaching within 300m without prior radio contact; shining lasers; training weapons; discharging firearms; maneuvering to force a course change; or transmitting threats.
AIS	Automatic Identification System, the maritime broadcast system that transmits vessel identity, position, course, speed, and status. Class A AIS is the standard for vessels over 300 gross tons.
MSB	The Maritime Stability Board, established under Annex Mi, which coordinates Hormuz transit operations, manages the CTC, and serves as the real-time monitoring authority.
Stand-off buffer	The minimum distance that an Iranian patrol boat or FAC maintains from any commercial vessel transiting the CTC. The standard stand-off buffer is 1 nautical mile (1,852 meters), measured by radar.
Weapons safe condition	A configuration in which: (a) all crew-served weapons — machine guns, cannons, rocket launchers, missile systems — are covered, stowed, or in a non-ready configuration; (b) small arms — rifles, pistols

Term	Meaning
	— remain holstered or slung on crew members, not in the hands or aimed; (c) no weapon, crew-served or individual, is trained on any other vessel; (d) ammunition is stowed in magazines or containers, not loaded in feed trays or chambers; and (e) missiles are in inactive mode with seeker heads covered.

Article 2 — Operating Zones and Prohibitions

2.1 Within the Commercial Transit Corridor (CTC)

The CTC is a protected transit lane for commercial shipping. The framework architecture applies the following prohibitions to all Iranian vessels within the CTC:

Prohibition	Applies To		Consequence
The framework architecture excludes Iranian patrol boats from the CTC except for three specified exceptions: (a) escorting at vessel master's request; (b) responding to declared distress; (c) transiting to/from port with 4-hour MSB notice and AIS broadcasting.	All	Iranian patrol boats	First violation: Tier 1. Second within 90 days: Tier 2 with 10% maritime benefit reduction for 72 hours.
The framework architecture excludes all Iranian FACs from the CTC under all circumstances, except in hot pursuit of a pirate vessel per UNCLOS Article 111 with immediate MSB notification within 5 minutes. Hot pursuit terminates immediately upon the pirate vessel's capture or escape; the FAC exits the CTC as soon as reasonably practicable, and in any event within 1 hour of termination. The FAC notifies the MSB of its estimated exit time within 10 minutes of termination. If weather or mechanical conditions prevent exit within 1 hour, the FAC requests an extension from the MSB, which the MSB grants for a reasonable period not exceeding an additional 2 hours.	All	Iranian FACs	Any FAC entry: automatic Tier 2. If weapons armed or personnel wear balaclavas: Tier 3.
No Iranian vessel comes within 1 nautical mile of any commercial vessel transiting the CTC. Brief incursion corrected within 2 minutes is	All	Iranian vessels	Automated alert via Annex W. Tier 1 if under 5 min and corrected. Tier 2 if persists beyond 5 min or repeated within 24 hours.

Prohibition	Applies To	Consequence
logged but does not trigger Tier classification.		
No Iranian vessel shines lasers, trains weapons, makes aggressive maneuvers, or transmits threats toward any commercial vessel. This prohibition operates as an absolute architectural feature with no exceptions.	All Iranian vessels	Immediate Tier 2. U.S. escort override authority under Annex N.a activates automatically. If weapons are discharged in the direction of a commercial vessel or U.S. escort: automatic Tier 3. If warning shots are fired away from any vessel — for example, into open water — after verbal warnings are ignored, the framework architecture classifies the incident as Tier 2 unless the warning shots cause injury or damage.

2.2 Within Iranian Territorial Waters (0–12 nm) but Outside the CTC

In the portion of Iranian territorial waters that does not overlap with the CTC, the framework architecture applies a differentiated rule set that preserves Iran’s coastal law enforcement authority while constraining high-risk vessel activity.

PGSA patrol boats (non-FAC) conduct normal law enforcement activities in this zone, including customs inspection, immigration control, safety inspection, and fisheries enforcement, in accordance with international law and UNCLOS. All such activities require continuous Class A AIS broadcasting. Boardings of commercial vessels in this zone require prior MSB notification and are limited to vessels that are entering or departing Iranian ports, not vessels in innocent passage transiting the Strait.

Fast attack craft (FACs) operate in this zone subject to the following constraints:

1. Continuous AIS broadcasting with unique vessel identifier, speed, course, and weapons status (armed/unarmed).
2. All weapons remain in safe condition at all times — no uncovered gun mounts, missiles in inactive mode, ammunition secured.
3. No approach within 500 meters of any commercial vessel that is lawfully transiting the CTC, even if the commercial vessel’s route carries it through the 0–12 nm zone. The CTC’s 1-nm stand-off buffer applies regardless of which zone the commercial vessel is physically in.
4. No speed exceeding 15 knots within 2 nautical miles of the CTC boundary.

High-speed operation is permitted only in the portion of the territorial waters zone that is at least 2 nm from any CTC boundary point.

5. No more than 4 FACs operate simultaneously in this zone. “Simultaneously” means within a 10-nautical-mile radius of the CTC boundary at the same time. The MSB counts FACs by radar tracks with unique MMSI identifiers; two FACs sharing one MMSI count as one vessel for this limit. The MSB tracks FAC count in real time and issues an alert if the count exceeds 4.

Transition rule: Any FAC that departs the 12-nm zone and enters international waters becomes subject immediately to the CTC rules of Article 2.1. The transition occurs at the moment the FAC’s AIS position report places it beyond the 12-nm limit. The FAC does not enjoy a transit buffer or grace period during this transition.

2.3 Beyond 12 Nautical Miles (International Waters)

In international waters of the Strait of Hormuz and Gulf of Oman, the framework architecture applies the strictest regime for Iranian small vessels:

Activity	Permitted ?	Conditions / Consequences
Routine transit of Iranian patrol boats (non-FAC)	Yes, with conditions	Class A AIS on. No weapons uncovered. No harassment. No approach within 1 nm of commercial vessels in CTC. Transit only; no loitering or station-keeping.
Fast attack craft (FAC) operations	No	The framework architecture excludes FACs from operating in international waters of the Strait/Hormuz area. Any FAC detected beyond 12 nm is presumed hostile. Presumption rebuttable only by MSB confirmation of distress.
Stops, boardings, or inspections of commercial vessels	No	No Iranian vessel possesses authority to stop, board, or inspect any commercial vessel in international waters. Any such attempt: automatic Tier 3 + \$10M escrow draw under Annex N.a.
Shadowing or following commercial vessels	No	Matching a commercial vessel's movement for more than 15 minutes within 2 nm constitutes harassment, regardless of distance from CTC.
Radio jamming or electronic interference	No	Any Iranian vessel that jams commercial or MSB communications frequencies commits automatic Tier 3. Interference with Annex W telemetry carries the same classification.

The zone-based architecture creates a simple mental model: the closer to commercial shipping, the stricter the rules. Inside the CTC, Iranian patrol boats are effectively excluded. Inside territorial waters but outside the CTC, patrol boats operate under constraint and FACs operate under heavy constraint. In international waters, FACs are excluded entirely and boardings are absolutely prohibited. This is not a negotiation position — it is an operational reality that both Parties live under once they adopt this Annex.

Article 3 — AIS and Telemetry Requirements

The framework architecture treats AIS broadcasting and telemetry as the primary verification mechanism for all Iranian patrol vessels. Vessels that broadcast transparently demonstrate good faith; vessels that fail to broadcast trigger the presumption of hostile intent.

Vessel Type	AIS Requirement	Additional Telemetry
PGSA patrol boats (non-FAC)	Class A AIS broadcasting 24/7 with unique MMSI registered with MSB. Vessel name, call sign, and PGSA affiliation displayed.	Position logged by MSB coastal radar every 5 minutes. Historical track retained for 90 days.
IRGC-Navy patrol boats (non-FAC)	Class A AIS broadcasting while underway. MMSI registered with MSB. Vessel name and IRGC-Navy affiliation displayed.	Live radar track shared with MSB via encrypted data link. Track updates every 2 minutes in Hormuz Transit Zone.
Fast attack craft (any force)	Unique identifier, speed, course, and weapons status broadcast via encrypted channel to MSB only. Simplified public AIS shows position and course only.	Real-time encrypted video feed to MSB when within 10 nm of CTC. Satellite imagery corroborates position and activity.
Small craft under 50 GT (RHIBs)	Class B AIS or unique radio beacon identifier registered with MSB if operated by military/paramilitary. Unmarked small craft are presumed hostile.	MSB observer vessels visually identify all small craft in CTC vicinity. Unidentified craft trigger immediate escort deployment under Annex N.a.

3.1 AIS Failure Protocol

If an Iranian vessel's AIS transmission fails during operation in or near the Hormuz Transit Zone, the following protocol activates:

- Notification requirement: Iran reports the AIS failure to the MSB within 1 hour of detection via the dedicated MSB communication channel (VHF 16 backup: INMARSAT-C). The report includes the vessel's last known position, intended route, and estimated repair time.
- Repair or exit: The vessel repairs its AIS and resumes broadcasting within 6

hours, or exits the Hormuz Transit Zone and returns to an Iranian port or anchorage beyond 15 nm from the CTC.

8. Presumption of hostile intent: If Iran does not report the failure within 1 hour, or if the vessel does not repair or exit within 6 hours, the framework architecture presumes hostile intent. The MSB issues an immediate alert to all commercial vessels in the area. U.S. escort vessels may intercept and identify the non-broadcasting vessel.
9. Good-faith burden shift: If the vessel demonstrates — through VHF 16 logs, engineering records, or MSB observer confirmation — that the failure was beyond its control and the crew made best efforts to report and repair, the presumption of hostile intent does not apply. Instead, the MSB logs the incident as a Tier 1 technical variance, and no further consequence follows. The vessel bears the burden of demonstrating good faith.
10. Good-faith override: If the vessel's AIS failure results from force majeure (extreme weather damage, electrical system failure beyond crew repair capability) and the crew demonstrates good faith by maintaining VHF 16 contact with the MSB and accepting U.S. or coalition escort to safe harbor, the presumption of hostile intent does not apply.

3.2 Weapons Status Reporting

Fast attack craft report their weapons status to the MSB via the encrypted channel at the following intervals: upon entering the Hormuz Transit Zone; every 4 hours while operating in the Hormuz Transit Zone; within 15 minutes of any weapons status change (arming or de-arming); upon exiting the Hormuz Transit Zone.

Weapons status categories are: (a) Fully de-armed — all weapons covered, missiles inactive, ammunition secured; (b) Patrol condition — small arms accessible to crew, crew-served weapons covered; (c) Armed — any crew-served weapon uncovered, missile system active, or ammunition loaded in feed tray. FACs in the territorial waters zone (0–12 nm) report “Fully de-armed” or “Patrol condition” only; “Armed” status is prohibited in this zone. FACs in the CTC are excluded entirely. Weapons status reports are not publicly broadcast; they are shared only with the MSB and the JMC.

The AIS and telemetry architecture is the transparency backbone of Annex Pa. It says to every Iranian patrol commander: if you have nothing to hide, broadcast. If your AIS is off, the architecture assumes you are hiding something — and the commercial vessels, the MSB, and the U.S. escorts respond accordingly. This is not surveillance overreach; it is mutual transparency. U.S. vessels broadcast too. Everyone sees everyone. That is what makes the Strait safe.

Article 4 — Verification and Detection

The framework architecture deploys a multi-layer verification system to detect, track, and verify compliance with the operating zone rules. No single sensor provides the full picture; the architecture correlates inputs from multiple independent sources to maximize detection confidence and minimize false positives.

4.1 Radar (Annex W)

The Maritime Stability Board operates a coastal radar network that detects all surface vessels within the Hormuz Transit Zone regardless of AIS status. The radar system provides continuous 360-degree coverage of the CTC and surrounding waters out to 30 nm from the Iranian coast. Automatic detection and tracking flags any vessel approaching within 3 nm of the CTC without prior MSB notification. Speed estimation is accurate to within 2 knots, sufficient to distinguish FACs (over 25 knots) from conventional patrol boats. Classification assistance through automatic radar cross-section (RCS) analysis flags small high-speed contacts for MSB operator review.

Any Iranian vessel detected within 3 nm of the CTC without AIS broadcasting triggers an automatic Tier 1 alert. If the vessel is classified as a FAC by RCS and speed analysis, the alert escalates to Tier 2 automatically.

4.2 Satellite Imagery

Commercial and government satellite assets provide optical and synthetic aperture radar (SAR) imagery for the Hormuz Transit Zone. Satellite verification captures vessel tracks and station-keeping patterns over time. Patterns consistent with shadowing, loitering near CTC entry/exit points, or coordinated multi-vessel operations are flagged for JMC review. High-resolution optical imagery (0.5m resolution or better) confirms weapons cover status on FACs operating in the territorial waters zone. Uncovered weapons in this zone constitute a Tier 2 violation. If a commercial vessel files a harassment complaint, satellite imagery provides independent corroboration or refutation of the complaint.

4.3 MSB Observer Vessels

Oman deploys at least one MSB observer vessel in the CTC at all times during daylight hours and maintains a 24/7 on-call deployment capability. The observer vessel provides direct visual observation of all vessel activity in the CTC, independent radar

tracking with data sharing to the MSB shore station, VHF 16 monitoring and relay of all maritime communications in the zone, immediate reporting of any harassment incident or stand-off buffer violation, and escort coordination with U.S. Navy vessels under Annex N.a when harassment or violation is detected.

The MSB observer vessel is unarmed and operates under Omani flag with diplomatic immunity. Its crew wears clearly identifiable MSB uniforms and maintains orange hull markings. Neither Party interferes with MSB observer vessel operations.

4.4 Commercial Vessel Reporting

Any commercial vessel master may file a harassment complaint via the MSB hotline (dedicated VHF 16 frequency, satellite phone, or secure email). The MSB answers all hotline calls within 2 minutes and logs the complaint within 15 minutes of receipt. The log includes: vessel name, IMO number, master's name, time and position of incident, description of the Iranian vessel, nature of harassment, and any injuries or damage.

The MSB investigates all complaints within 6 hours. The investigation correlates the complaint with radar tracks, satellite imagery, AIS records, and MSB observer vessel reports. The MSB issues a preliminary factual finding within 24 hours. A commercial vessel master who files three or more complaints that the MSB determines to be materially false or fabricated faces loss of hotline priority status and potential civil liability for damages to Iranian reputation.

Article 5 — Escalation and Response

The framework architecture applies graduated consequences for violations of this Annex. The escalation matrix below specifies the automatic consequence and U.S. response authority for each violation category. The PCC reviews all automatic classifications and may adjust the Tier based on mitigating or aggravating circumstances, but the initial classification activates immediately upon detection.

Incident	Automatic Consequence	U.S. Response Authority
Patrol boat (non-FAC) enters CTC without prior MSB notification	Tier 1 for first violation. Tier 2 (10% reduction, 72 hours) for second within 90 days. Tier 3 for third within 180 days.	U.S. issues warning via MSB VHF 16. U.S. escort may shadow the patrol boat until it exits the CTC.
FAC enters CTC under any circumstances	Automatic Tier 2. If weapons armed: Tier 3. If personnel wear balaclavas: Tier 3 + \$5M additional escrow draw.	U.S. orders FAC to leave CTC via VHF 16. If ignored or vessel advances, U.S. employs proportional force: warning shots, disabling fire. No prior PCC authorization required.
Iranian vessel within 500m of commercial vessel in CTC	Tier 2. Penalty doubles to 20% reduction if within 300m.	U.S. escort override activates automatically under Annex N.a. U.S. escort positions itself between Iranian vessel and commercial vessel.
Harassment (lasers, weapons training, aggressive maneuvering, threats)	Immediate Tier 2. If weapons are discharged in the direction of a commercial vessel or U.S. escort: automatic Tier 3 + \$10M escrow draw. If warning shots are fired away from any vessel — for example, into open water — after verbal warnings are ignored, the framework architecture classifies the incident as Tier 2 (material disruption) unless the warning shots cause injury or damage.	U.S. escort override activates. U.S. may employ all necessary force to protect the commercial vessel, including return of fire if Iranian vessel fires first.
Iranian vessel fires upon or boards a commercial vessel	Automatic Tier 3 + \$10M penalty from Iran's escrow. Full structural consequence assessment under Annex T.	U.S. employs all necessary force to protect vessel and crew, including sinking the Iranian craft. No further PCC authorization required. U.S. notifies PCC within 1 hour.
FAC operates in	Automatic Tier 3. FAC's	U.S. issues warning via MSB and

Incident	Automatic Consequence	U.S. Response Authority
international waters (beyond 12 nm)	presence beyond 12 nm is presumptive evidence of hostile interdiction intent.	requests immediate FAC return to territorial waters. U.S. may shadow and intercept if FAC approaches within 2 nm of any commercial vessel.
Unauthorized boarding in international waters	Automatic Tier 3 + \$10M escrow draw. Triggers full Annex N.a backdoor closure penalties in addition to Annex Pa consequences.	U.S. employs all necessary force to terminate boarding and secure commercial vessel's release. PCC convenes emergency session within 6 hours.
AIS failure without timely report or repair/exit	Presumption of hostile intent triggers Tier 2 automatically. Tier 3 if vessel approaches within 1 nm of commercial vessel during outage.	U.S. escort vessel intercepts and identifies non-broadcasting vessel via visual and radio contact. U.S. maintains safe stand-off unless vessel demonstrates hostile behavior.
Radio jamming or electronic interference with MSB or commercial communications	Automatic Tier 3. Electronic interference with Annex W telemetry carries same classification.	U.S. locates jamming source via direction-finding and issues cease-and-desist warning. If jamming continues, U.S. employs electronic countermeasures.

5.1 Proportional Force Standard

The framework architecture defines proportional force as the minimum level of force necessary to achieve the following objectives: (a) compel the Iranian vessel to exit the CTC or cease its prohibited activity; (b) protect the commercial vessel and its crew from harm; (c) avoid unnecessary escalation to broader conflict. Proportional force follows a graduated ladder:

11. Level 1 — Verbal warning: VHF 16 broadcast ordering the Iranian vessel to cease its activity and exit the CTC.
12. Level 2 — Visual warning: Signal flags, loudhailer, or searchlight signals indicating that the vessel is in violation and must comply.
13. Level 3 — Warning shots: Fired across the bow of the Iranian vessel, away from the commercial vessel. Warning shots are the first kinetic response and are employed only when verbal and visual warnings are ignored.

14. Level 4 — Disabling fire: Precision fire targeting the Iranian vessel's propulsion or steering systems to render it incapable of continuing its prohibited activity. Disabling fire avoids targeting crew compartments or weapons magazines unless the vessel fires first.
15. Level 5 — Lethal force: Employed only when the Iranian vessel fires upon the U.S. escort, the commercial vessel, or crew members. Lethal force includes return of fire, sinking the vessel if necessary, and boarding to secure personnel. Boarding operations are conducted only after notifying the MSB and, if feasible, the Iranian flag state via the PCC back-channel. This notification requirement adds accountability without constraining the tactical commander's authority to protect life and vessel.

The U.S. escort commander has full authority to determine the appropriate force level based on the tactical situation. The commander does not require real-time PCC approval for any force level. The commander reports the engagement to the PCC and JMC within 1 hour of its conclusion.

The escalation matrix is the architecture's teeth. It tells Iranian commanders exactly what happens if they violate the rules — not as a threat, but as a predictable operational reality. The matrix is automatic: a FAC enters the CTC, and Tier 2 activates. The matrix is graduated: a brief radar blip gets a warning; a boarding gets lethal force. The matrix is symmetrical: U.S. violations are reported, investigated, and sanctioned through the same PCC process. This is not a one-sided imposition. It is a mutual architecture for preventing the small-vessel incidents that have brought the Strait to the brink of war before.

Article 6 — Reciprocal U.S. and Coalition Obligations

The framework architecture applies symmetrical restrictions to U.S. and coalition patrol vessels operating in the Hormuz Transit Zone. These restrictions ensure that neither Party enjoys a unilateral freedom of action and that commercial vessels are protected from harassment by any nation's forces.

16. CTC stand-off: U.S. and coalition patrol vessels maintain a stand-off distance of 1 nautical mile from all commercial vessels transiting the CTC, except when actively escorting a commercial vessel under Annex N.a or responding to a distress call. For the avoidance of doubt, escorting vessels operating under Annex N.a approach to within 300 meters of the escorted commercial vessel, and station themselves between the commercial vessel and any perceived threat. All other stand-off rules apply to third-party vessels.
17. AIS broadcasting: All U.S. Navy vessels broadcast Class A AIS continuously while in the Hormuz Transit Zone. U.S. vessels maintain an open radio channel on VHF 16 for direct communication with the MSB, commercial vessels, and Iranian patrol boats.
18. Territorial waters exclusion: No U.S. vessel enters Iranian territorial waters (0–12 nm) without prior mutual written agreement, except in hot pursuit of a pirate vessel as defined by UNCLOS Article 111.
19. Harassment prohibition: U.S. and coalition vessels do not shine lasers, train weapons, make aggressive maneuvers, or transmit threats toward Iranian patrol boats operating lawfully in their permitted zones. This prohibition applies even if the Iranian vessel is not broadcasting AIS.
20. FAC-equivalent restrictions: U.S. small combatants (including Mark VI patrol boats, special operations craft, and any vessel capable of sustained speed exceeding 25 knots) do not enter Iranian territorial waters under any circumstances.

6.1 Reciprocal Violation Process

If Iran alleges a violation by a U.S. or coalition vessel, Iran files a complaint with the MSB using the same hotline and procedure as commercial vessel complaints. The MSB investigates the complaint within 6 hours, using the same radar, satellite, and observer vessel data sources. If the MSB confirms a U.S. violation, the PCC determines

the appropriate reciprocal step-back through a symmetrical process: First confirmed U.S. violation: Tier 1 technical variance, documented caution. Second confirmed U.S. violation within 90 days: Tier 2, with U.S. escort vessels limited to two concurrent patrols in the CTC for 72 hours. Third confirmed U.S. violation within 180 days: Tier 3, with full structural consequence assessment. During the 72-hour Tier 3 period, U.S. escort vessels are excluded from the CTC entirely; Omani MSB observer vessels assume sole escort responsibility.

The symmetrical process ensures that the architecture binds both Parties equally. Neither Party claims exemption from the rules that apply to the other.

Article 7 — De Minimis and Good-Faith Exceptions

The framework architecture recognizes that perfect compliance is operationally impossible and that minor, unintentional deviations do not threaten the overall security of the Strait. The following exceptions apply:

21. Navigation error: A brief, unintentional entry into the CTC due to navigation error — for example, compass malfunction, GPS spoofing, or helmsman error — corrected within 10 minutes upon MSB warning, does not constitute a breach. The MSB issues a warning but does not assign Tier classification. Iran reports the navigation error and its cause to the MSB within 2 hours. A pattern of three or more "navigation errors" within any 90-day period voids this exception for the vessel involved for the remainder of that 90-day period and for the subsequent 90 days.
22. AIS mechanical failure: Mechanical failure of AIS equipment does not constitute a violation if Iran reports the failure to the MSB within 1 hour, the vessel maintains continuous VHF 16 communication with the MSB as an alternative position-reporting method, and the vessel repairs the AIS or exits the Hormuz Transit Zone within 6 hours.
23. Humanitarian and search-and-rescue exemption: Any vessel engaged in bona fide humanitarian operations or search-and-rescue (SAR) is exempt from all zone-based prohibitions and AIS requirements, provided the vessel broadcasts "SAR" on AIS and notifies the MSB of its humanitarian status before or immediately upon entering the exempted zone.
24. Force majeure: Vessels driven into prohibited zones by extreme weather, mechanical failure, or medical emergency are exempt from Tier classification, provided the vessel's master notifies the MSB immediately, accepts MSB-coordinated assistance, and makes all reasonable efforts to exit the prohibited zone as soon as conditions permit.
25. Pre-authorized technical transit: Iranian patrol boats may transit the CTC for technical reasons (vessel transfer between Iranian ports, equipment testing, crew training) with 48 hours' prior MSB notification, continuous AIS broadcasting, weapons in safe condition, and speed not exceeding 10 knots. The MSB approves or denies the request within 24 hours. Denial is not appealable but does not constitute a breach finding.

The de minimis exceptions are the architecture's safety valve. They prevent the Tier system from activating over trivial incidents — a GPS glitch, a broken antenna, a sailor at the wheel who misreads a chart. But they are narrow, time-bound, and pattern-sensitive. Three "navigation errors" in a month stops being an error and starts being a tactic. The architecture knows the difference.

Article 8 — Relationship to Other Annexes

The table below specifies the operative relationship between this Annex and each relevant provision of the MOU architecture.

Annex / Provision			Relationship
Annex N	(Non-Interdiction)		Annex Pa operates as a specific enforcement rule set for patrol boats and FACs. It does not replace Annex N. The absolute non-interdiction prohibition of Annex N remains in force for all vessel types. Annex Pa adds zone-based granularity and telemetry requirements for small vessels.
Annex N.a	(Backdoor Closure)		A patrol boat interdiction or unauthorized boarding triggers the automatic \$10M penalty and U.S. escort authority of Annex N.a in addition to the Tier classification of Annex Pa. The consequences are cumulative, not alternative.
Annex Mi	(Maritime Implementation)		Annex Mi defines the CTC coordinates, transit procedures, and commercial vessel rights. Annex Pa defines the restrictions on Iranian small vessels that protect those commercial rights. The two annexes are complementary.
Annex W	(Maritime Telemetry)		All telemetry data from Iranian patrol boats — AIS, radar, satellite, video — feeds into the Annex W compliance dashboard. The JMC and MSB access Annex W data for real-time monitoring and post-incident investigation.
Annex Mo	(JMC)		The JMC monitors patrol boat compliance as part of its Daily Compliance Bulletin function. The JMC does not independently classify violations; it reports factual data to the PCC for Tier classification.
Annex T	(Step-Back Protocol)		All Tier classifications under Annex Pa are implemented through the Annex T step-back architecture. Tier 1, 2, and 3 procedures are defined in Annex T and apply to Annex Pa violations without modification.
MOU Article 8.5	(Exit Ramp)		Withdrawal from the MOU under Article 8.5 terminates all obligations under Annex Pa. However, the \$10M escrow draw for a Tier 3 violation that occurred before withdrawal remains enforceable.

Article 9 — Incorporation by Reference

This Annex is incorporable into any existing or future agreement through the following adoption sentence:

“The Parties adopt Annex Pa (Patrol Boat and Fast Attack Craft Protocol) as an operative provision of this Agreement. This Annex governs the operating zones, AIS requirements, and prohibited activities for all Iranian patrol vessels, with special rules for fast attack craft. In the event of any inconsistency, Annex Pa governs over Annex N with respect to small vessel conduct. Reciprocal obligations bind U.S. and coalition vessels equally.”

No amendment of the parent MOU is required for this Annex to enter into force. This Annex enters into force upon signature by both Parties or provisional application by exchange of diplomatic notes.

The entry-into-force mechanisms are:

26. Signature: Physical or electronic signature by the authorized representative of each Party, consistent with MOU Article 12.
27. Provisional application: Exchange of diplomatic notes confirming that each Party applies this Annex provisionally pending signature. Provisional application carries the same binding effect as signature for the duration of the provisional period.
28. Automatic integration: If this Annex is adopted by the incorporation sentence above, it enters into force simultaneously with the agreement that adopts it.

The incorporation sentence makes clear that Annex Pa supersedes Annex N only on the specific question of small vessel conduct. Annex N’s absolute non-interdiction prohibition remains intact. This is not a replacement; it is a refinement. The architecture adds granularity where granularity is needed — on the vessels that pose the highest risk of miscalculation and escalation.

Signature Block

In witness whereof, the undersigned, being duly authorized by their respective governments, have signed this Annex Pa: Patrol Boat and Fast Attack Craft Protocol.

Done at _____, this ____ day of _____, 2026, in duplicate in the English language.

For the United States of America:	For the Islamic Republic of Iran:
Name: _____	Name: _____
Title: _____	Title: _____
Signature: _____	Signature: _____
Date: _____	Date: _____

Witnessed by Oman (MSB Host Nation):

Name: _____ Title: _____

Signature: _____ Date: _____

Maritime Stability Board, Muscat, Sultanate of Oman